

Uttar Pradesh has been named and shamed as the state with the lowest tiger numbers. In its defence, the state says those adding up the numbers have got their counting all wrong.

■ **By Subhash Mishra**

It was launched with much fanfare in 1973. But after the initial success, the teeth seem to be falling out of Project Tiger. Confirming conservationists' worst fears, the government-run National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) recently released startling figures around the magnificent predator: from 3,642 in 2002 tiger numbers in India have fallen to 1,411 in 2008. It was revealed that the tiger was en route to extinction in Uttar Pradesh, which had the lowest numbers, a mere 109. The release of NTCA figures has triggered a confrontation between the Uttar Pradesh government and the men behind the alarming new figures.

Instead of accepting culpability for a shocking decline in the tiger population, authorities in Uttar Pradesh say that NTCA has got its counting all wrong. Agitated by NTCA's claim that Uttar Pradesh has only 109 big cats, Principal Chief Wildlife Warden D.L. Suman told INDIA TODAY that the new methodology of camera-trapping used by NTCA was faulty and therefore its results were unreliable. The state Forest Department maintains that the numbers are much higher than NTCA claims and stands by the 2005 census figure of 273 instead. Suman accused NTCA of failing to count sub-adult tigers and those living in the sugarcane fields.

Refusing this contention, NTCA member-secretary Rajesh Gopal says Suman's remarks are "most unfortunate". This census, he says, was carried



PREYING ON THE

out following a double-sample method of camera-trapping supported by field evidence. "The census figures aren't meant to humiliate anyone," Gopal says, adding, "instead, this cascading situation should be improved." This is the first time the camera-trapping method has been used in all the 17 states with tiger dwellings as opposed to the earlier pug-mark

impression method.

India's tiger population faces a serious threat due to poaching, erosion of habitat and shrinking of the forest areas as a result of industrialisation, mining activities and urbanisation. The 2005 census figures did not convince professional tiger watchers and conservationists.

The news of the decimation of tiger populations in Sariska, Rajasthan in 2005 prove their fears as justified. On an average, 30 tigers die in India every year, out of which only 40 per cent die a natural death and the rest 60 per cent fall prey to poaching. Senior Superintendent of Police of Special Task Force (STF), Lucknow, Amitabh Yash says STF, apart from the forest officials, has nabbed nearly 50 poachers and recovered a dozen tiger skins in the

PLAYING THE BLAME GAME

■ NTCA says 109 tigers are left in Uttar Pradesh, while the state Forest Department stands by its 2005 figure of 273.

■ Despite NTCA's constant alerts of the dwindling tiger population to the state, nothing has been done.

■ While NTCA uses camera-trapping to track tigers, the state calls the method unreliable as tigers also take abode in the sugarcane fields, searching for prey.

■ NTCA blames the state for not paying heed to its advisories.